

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 572

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Centenary United Methodist Church upon the dedication of its historical marker.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should recognize and celebrate those historic institutions that have played a vital role in the civic, educational, and spiritual life of this State and its citizens; and

WHEREAS, one such venerable institution is Centenary United Methodist Church, which dedicated its historical marker on November 20, 2025, at 3:00 p.m., at its current location at 584 East McLemore Avenue in Memphis; and

WHEREAS, the marker, approved by the Tennessee Historical Commission, stands as a tribute to the sacrifices, struggles, bravery, and resilience of Centenary United Methodist Church's pastors and congregations and serves as a solemn reminder of the enduring costs of progress and freedom; and

WHEREAS, Centenary United Methodist Church and its accompanying school were founded in 1865 by the Methodist Episcopal Church North, originally located on Raburn Street near downtown Memphis; and

WHEREAS, from the church's earliest days, its pastors and members engaged in civil action and community leadership, establishing the church as a cornerstone of faith and justice in the city of Memphis; and

WHEREAS, after the church burned during the Memphis Massacre of 1866, the congregation reconstructed the building in January 1867, continuing its ministry of hope and perseverance; and

WHEREAS, Centenary United Methodist Church's affiliated school educated a generation of students who became some of Memphis's first Black teachers, and its parsonage

housed the first kindergarten for Black children in the city; in addition, the first Black Boy Scout troop in Memphis was organized at the church; and

WHEREAS, throughout the twentieth century, Centenary United Methodist Church's leadership and congregation remained at the forefront of the struggle for equality and civil rights; and

WHEREAS, under the guidance of Dr. H.B. Gibson, pastor and local NAACP president, the church was instrumental in advancing voting rights during the 1940s; and

WHEREAS, in the 1960s, Centenary United Methodist Church's ministry reached national significance under Reverend Dr. James M. Lawson, Jr., whose leadership made the church a vital organizing hub for civil rights efforts in Memphis and beyond; and

WHEREAS, in 1966, Centenary United Methodist Church served as a site for strategic planning to ensure that James Meredith's March Against Fear, from Memphis to Jackson, Mississippi, would continue after Mr. Meredith was shot; church member and attorney A.W. Willis, Jr., served as Mr. Meredith's local counsel; and

WHEREAS, in 1968, as tensions mounted between Black sanitation workers and Memphis officials, Reverend James Lawson and Centenary's congregation hosted meetings urging city leaders to provide fair working conditions; when no agreement was reached, the workers organized their strike meetings at the church, shaping a pivotal chapter in the nation's Civil Rights Movement; and

WHEREAS, at Reverend Lawson's invitation, Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., came to Memphis to support the sanitation workers' cause, and strategy sessions were held at Centenary; and

WHEREAS, following Dr. King's assassination on April 4, 1968, two Centenary United Methodist Church members—Clara Ester, who attempted to aid Dr. King on the balcony, and Robert S. Lewis, Jr., who prepared his body for burial—bore direct witness to history; and

WHEREAS, in the years since, Centenary United Methodist Church has remained steadfast in its calling to serve, teach, and uplift, preserving the memory of those who came before while fostering a vibrant and compassionate community; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Centenary United Methodist Church upon the dedication of its historical marker, recognizing its 160 years of extraordinary service, leadership, and witness in the pursuit of faith, equality, and community progress.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.